

havoc on society with their misdeeds. To curb such fanatic movements and nip the problem in its bud, fellow community members should socially boycott such operatives and go all out against the preachers who indoctrinate vulnerable minds. The problem can largely be solved. Religion, one must remember, should foster harmony and unity in society, not hatred and violence.

A.K. GHOSH, on e-mail

Conflict Within

While liberal non-Muslims are vocal and hyperactive about measures to assuage the angst of the Muslims, the response of opinion leaders of the community leaves much to be desired ("Under Siege", October 20). It will be unrealistic to assume that the hang-over of pre-Partition politics is unrelated to the sense of alienation that the community gets subjected to. Its leaders have done precious little to erase history; instead, some of them are trying to revive it, thereby augmenting the unhealthy mindset of separatism.

BISHAN SAHAI, on e-mail

The voices of agony arising out of marginalised and discriminating treatment meted out to the Muslim community should serve as an eye-opener to the powers that be in the country. It was even more shocking to read another report that two policemen on security duty for the Kozhikode visit of the Opposition leader, L.K. Advani, were relieved of their responsibility at the eleventh hour because they were Muslims. This inci-

dent is indeed unfortunate and a blot on India's secular credentials. But are we as secular as we claim? Why is there such a widening gap between what we preach and what we practice?

G.S. PAUL, Thrissur

Politics of Votes

It is nothing else but petty votebank politics that dictates the terms and conditions of our leaders as is evident from the stance adopted by them and their

parties in Assam. ("Bleeding Faultlines", October 20). The influx of illegal migrants from Bangladesh is on the rise, but the Assam Government isn't bothered. Do politicians want to convert Assam into another Kashmir? Or would they rather gather electoral advantage from this influx of Bangladeshi migrants, garner votes and then happily make it a poll issue? No doubt, patriotism fetches maximum political gains.

MAYA AGARWAL, on e-mail

THE BIGGER BATTLE



Since Independence, every pay commission inadvertently lowered the status of the armed forces ("The War of Wages", October 20). As a result, our youth refuse to join the services. This is apparent from the glaring shortage of over 13,000 officers. This does not augur well for safety of the country. In order to reverse this trend, it is vital that our political masters and policymakers do something with immediate effect to strengthen the armed forces. It requires sustained effort, patriotic fervour and zealous leadership. A career in the forces must attract the crème de la crème.

BRIGADIER (ret'd) GOVIND SINGH KHIMTA, Shimla

The chiefs did not send the service instructions for the implementation of the pay panel's recommendations because they didn't want any unrest among the ranks. By doing so, they safeguarded the honour, welfare and comfort of the men and women they command. Hats off to them for taking a firm stand on the matter.

COLONEL (ret'd) M.N.S. THAMPI, Thiruvananthapuram

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Years Ago in India Today

NOVEMBER 16-30, 1978

Tarakeshwari Sinha



Hot Favourite

With the battle of Chikmagalur over, the die is cast for the Lok Sabha byelection in Samastipur parliamentary constituency in north Bihar on November 26. The Congress (I) has chosen to put up 51-year-old Tarakeshwari Sinha, a former Union deputy minister for finance. The ebullient Sinha who retains her sense of humour and charm in spite of the strains of a fluctuating political career, attracted a big crowd when she arrived in Samastipur to file her nomination. Opposing her, apart from 21 other candidates, is the surprise Janata Party nominee, Ajit Kumar Mehta. A Koeri by caste, this young professor of technology at Ranchi is an unknown entity in the state politics. Caste would be the most important factor in the election. Sinha, a Bhumihar, is confident of securing full support of her community. She also expects support from Harijans and Muslims, traditionally loyal to the Congress party. Maithili Brahmins who are irked at their language being declared an optional subject at secondary educational level, are also expected to favour Sinha.

—Farzand Ahmed